his associates, reported that his wife sets the agenda for his diplomatic trips and advises him on high-level decisions. One adviser recalled asking Netanyahu how to draft a briefing on the prisoner swap with Hamas that freed Gilad Shalit, the Israeli soldier captured in 2006. “Ask my wife what she thinks,” he said. Netanyahu did not respond to the specific allegations. Instead he sent the channel a remarkable three-page tirade, a personal attack that called the presenter, Ilana Dayan, an “extreme leftist” who “hates the prime minister”. She read the entire message at the end of the program in a theatrical segment that lasted more than six minutes. “The time has come to unmask Ilana Dayan, who has proved once again that she has not even a drop of professional integrity,” the prime minister wrote. “Dayan’s show this evening demonstrates perfectly why the media industry needs to undergo reform.”

A few weeks later, amidst a swirl of new stories about official corruption, he posted a late-night screed against Raviv Drucker on his Facebook page. “Through daily brainwashing of the public, and character assassination of me and my family, they hope to distract the public’s attention from the core issues of political debate in Israel,” he wrote.

He was asked about all of this in the winter of 2016, at an annual toast for the foreign press corps: should a head of state offer such sharp criticism of the media? Encouraged, perhaps, by Donald Trump’s recent election, he flippantly dismissed the criticism. “It’s fun, I enjoy it,” he said.

Religion and state

Yisrael Katz was perhaps the only man in Israel wishing he had hit more traffic on the way to work. The transportation minister, a Likud stalwart with nearly two decades in the Knesset, strode into the prime minister’s office with an unconvincing grin plastered onto his face. The cabinet was gathering for its weekly meeting, and the rumor swirling around Jerusalem was that it might be Katz’s last. He remained overtly buoyant throughout the discussion—at least the part of it open to the press. But the tension in the room was palpable. Katz didn’t exchange a single word with the man sitting next to him, his boss, who wasted little time going after his latest enemy. “Ministers are appointed in order to avoid crises and solve problems, not create them,” Netanyahu said sternly. He didn’t look at Katz. He didn’t have to.